

Weekend Healthcare Pulse: Global medical imaging - AI Innovation from the land of Silicon Valley

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As AI and machine learning excel at pattern recognition and anomaly detection, image analysis is one of the healthcare segments best suited for adoption. Over the past decade, leading imaging companies, major technology firms, and a growing number of start-ups have introduced AI-driven tools aimed at improving both the speed and accuracy of lesion detection. In today's Weekend Healthcare Pulse, we examine several prominent start-ups and recently IPO-listed players in radiology, focusing on how they are using AI to enhance clinical workflows and the competitive dynamics between these players and the incumbent OEMs.

By Susannah Ludwig, Estelle Pang and Richard Hombach

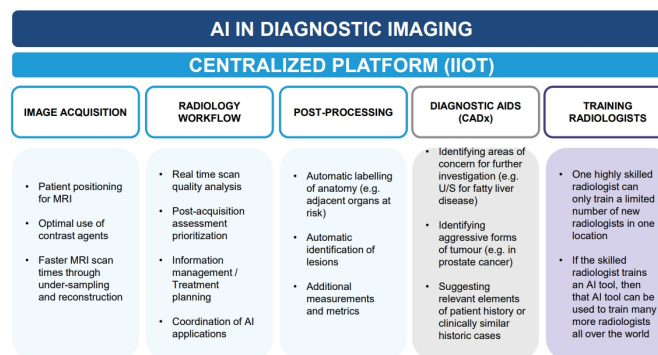
RADIOLOGY IS THE MOST ADVANCED SUBMARKET FOR AI ADOPTION IN MEDTECH

Radiology is widely regarded as the most advanced submarket for AI adoption within medtech, primarily because it involves a pattern recognition problem applied to vast volumes of medical images, supported by highly structured and repeatable workflows. Radiologists routinely interpret thousands of images across modalities such as CT, MRI, and X-ray, making the specialty particularly amenable to algorithmic assistance. In this context, AI offers clear and measurable efficiency gains by helping clinicians manage rising scan volumes, reducing reporting workloads, and prioritizing time sensitive cases more effectively.

AI applications are already being embedded across multiple stages of the radiology workflow. These include image acquisition, workflow coordination, post-processing analysis, as well as follow-up management and training (Exhibit 1). In the long-term, there is potential in transforming radiology from a discipline of qualitative interpretation to one of quantitative analysis. This shift is often referred to as radiomics. But in imaging, and in medtech more broadly, AI's main impact in the near to medium-term will likely be more around speeding up workflows, increasing the efficiency of radiology suites, reducing errors, and improving the accuracy of

diagnosis.

EXHIBIT 1: AI application in Diagnostic Imaging



Source: Bernstein analysis

COVID-19 HAS BEEN A WAKE-UP CALL FOR HOSPITALS TO INVEST FOR EFFICIENCY

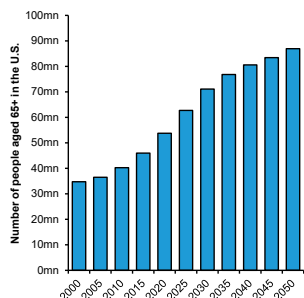
Prior to the pandemic, equipment and healthcare IT vendors often struggled to persuade hospitals to adopt new technologies. Many advanced software solutions were seen as useful but not essential,

making it difficult to justify investment during procurement. This mindset shifted in 2020, when COVID-19 forced hospitals to rapidly expand ICU capacity and operate more efficiently to manage surging patient volumes. In the aftermath, radiology departments faced significant backlogs, with the pressure persisting as long-term trends continued to intensify. An aging population, as baby boomers move into higher-care years, is increasing demand for imaging services while ongoing staff shortages are pressuring capacity. As a result, the need for technologies that improve efficiency and streamline workflows in the radiology suite persists.

AGING POPULATION SUSTAINING RADIOLOGY DEMAND

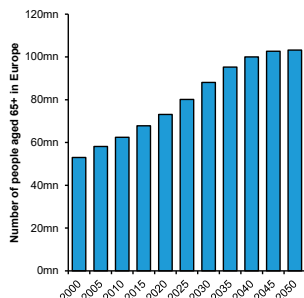
Demographic trends are set to provide a sustained tailwind for diagnostic imaging demand over the coming decade. Aging populations, in particular, are a primary driver, as older individuals typically require more frequent imaging procedures to manage chronic conditions and monitor disease progression. According to the World Bank, the population aged 65 and above is projected to grow at roughly +3% annually through 2030 in the US (Exhibit 2), while Europe is expected to see a growth rate of around +2% over the same period (Exhibit 3). As a result, the underlying demand for basic diagnostic imaging services is likely to remain robust in the medium-term, reinforcing the importance of workflow optimization solutions to help providers keep pace with rising volumes.

EXHIBIT 2: The U.S. senior population will grow at a 3% CAGR through 2030



Source: World Bank estimates (>2020), Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 3: The European senior population will grow at a 2% CAGR through 2030



Source: World Bank estimates (>2020), Bernstein analysis

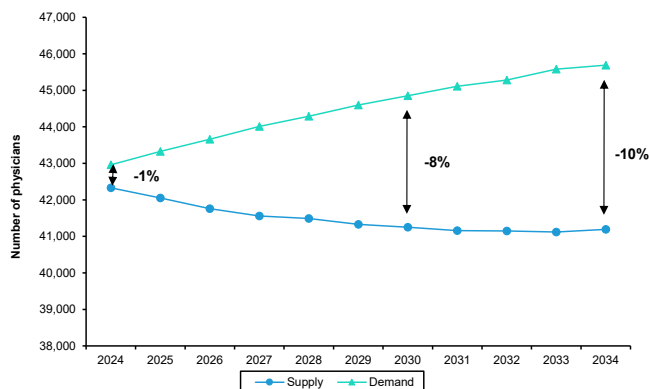
AI CAN ALLEVIATE STAFFING SHORTAGES BY FREEING UP TIME FOR HOSPITAL STAFF

Labor shortages have been a persistent and structural challenge across healthcare systems, particularly in the United States, and continue to act as a key constraint on radiology throughput. According to the U.S. Health Resources and Services Administration's National Center for Health Workforce Analysis, supply growth of radiology physicians categories is expected to lag demand well into the 2030s. The gap between demand and supply is expected to reach -10% by 2034 (Exhibit 4). As a result, labor availability remains the primary bottleneck to improving imaging

volumes and reducing backlogs, meaning that efficiency gains will be critical to meeting growing demand.

EXHIBIT 4: The gap between U.S. demand and supply of physicians in radiology is expected to reach -10% by 2034

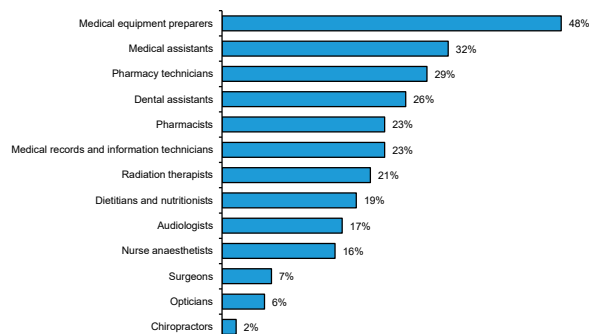
Estimated supply and demand for radiology physicians (2024-2034E)



Source: Projection from the US Department of Health and Human Services, Health Resources and Services Administration, Bernstein analysis

AI driven workflow innovation represents one of the most promising levers for alleviating these pressures. Rather than replacing clinical roles, AI has the potential to augment staff productivity by automating repetitive and time intensive tasks across the care pathway. According to a [McKinsey industry report](#), AI could free up to 48% of a medical equipment preparer's time, or 23% for a pharmacist (Exhibit 5). Applied to radiology, similar gains in areas such as image triage, documentation, and coordination could meaningfully expand effective capacity without requiring proportional increases in headcount, positioning AI as a critical enabler of more resilient and scalable imaging workflows in the years ahead.

EXHIBIT 5: AI could free up a significant amount of time for hospital staff



Source: McKinsey Global Institute, Bernstein analysis

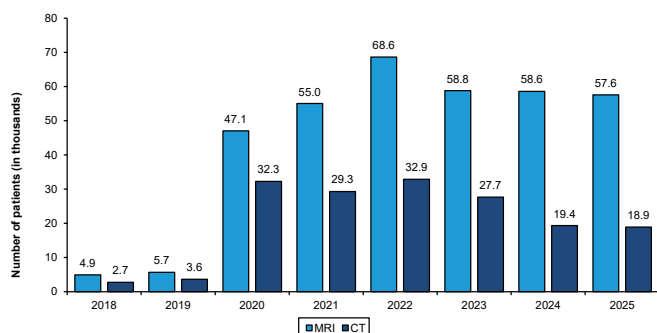
LONG WAIT TIMES DRIVING NEED FOR EFFICIENCY IMPROVEMENTS

Long wait times have emerged as one of the most visible and pressing consequences of the structural constraints facing radiology, reinforcing the urgency for workflow efficiency improvements. The deferral of non-urgent procedures during the COVID pandemic created a substantial backlog that healthcare systems have struggled to unwind, even as operations normalize. Despite efforts to expand capacity through incremental hiring and equipment upgrades in the post-pandemic period, waiting lists in many regions remain elevated. The NHS provides a particularly clear example of this dynamic: the number of patients in England waiting more than six weeks for a CT or MRI scan surged from approximately 8,000 pre-pandemic to around 80,000 in 2020, and remains persistently high at roughly 75,000 in 2025 (Exhibit 6).

This sustained backlog underscores a fundamental challenge: healthcare systems face finite labor pools and slow-moving capacity expansion cycles, making it difficult to materially increase throughput through conventional means alone. As a result, reducing wait times is increasingly dependent on improving productivity within existing labor resources. This requires enabling the same number of radiologists and imaging systems to handle greater volumes, which in turn necessitates faster image acquisition, streamlined workflows, and more efficient interpretation. AI-enabled solutions are particularly well positioned to address these bottlenecks by accelerating scan protocols, automating prioritization of urgent cases, and reducing reporting turnaround times. Efficiency gains driven by AI are not merely incremental improvements, but a critical lever for addressing systemic delays and ensuring timely patient access to diagnostic services.

EXHIBIT 6: The number of patients who had to wait at least six weeks for a CT or an MRI more than quadrupled between 2019 and 2020, and continues to be elevated compared to pre-pandemic

Patients waiting six weeks or more for a MRI or CT scan at NHS



Source: NHS website, Bernstein analysis

HOW IS SILICON VALLEY STEPPING IN TO SOLVE THE PROBLEMS IN RADIOLOGY

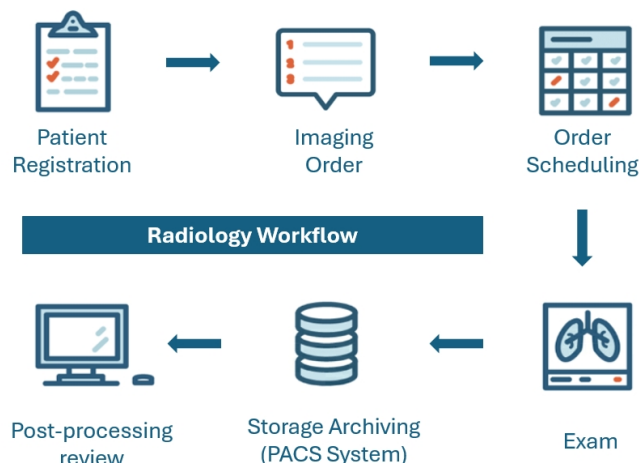
STARTUPS ARE ADVANCING IN AI-ENABLED SOFTWARE SOLUTIONS

Against the backdrop of mounting pressure on radiology departments, start-ups are stepping in to address these systemic inefficiencies through the development of advanced, AI-enabled software solutions. These firms are rethinking radiology workflows, from image acquisition to reporting and clinical decision support. By leveraging machine learning, automation, and cloud-based platforms, these technologies aim to streamline operations, reduce administrative burden, and enable radiologists to focus on higher-value clinical tasks. The following section highlights several leading startups at the forefront of this transformation, examining the specific challenges they target and the innovative approaches they are deploying to enhance efficiency across the radiology ecosystem.

Radiology workflow

A typical radiology workflow follows a structured sequence that begins with patient registration, followed by the creation of an imaging order, scheduling, examinations, data archiving (typically in a Picture Archiving and Communication System (PACS)) and reporting review. (Exhibit 7).

EXHIBIT 7: A summary of radiology workflow



Source: Bernstein analysis

Storage archiving solutions

In recent years, many of the radiology workflow solutions have focused on the storage and archiving phase, particularly within PACS and adjacent systems. The PACS stores images captured from scanners, organizes them by patient and exam, and makes them instantly available on diagnostic workstations and other

screens inside or outside the hospital. This stage serves as a critical central hub where imaging data is aggregated, retrieved, and prepared for interpretation. AI-enabled solutions are increasingly being deployed here to enhance data management, automate image prioritization, and pre-analyze scans before radiologist review.

Aidoc (April 2026 Series E, \$520m valuation)

Aidoc is a privately held company, headquartered in Israel. The company's core focus is AI-enabled analysis of CT and X-ray scans, embedded into the radiology workflow via its aiOS and CARE platforms (Exhibit 8), which plug into PACS and hospital systems to run "always-on" image analysis, triage acute findings, and coordinate downstream care teams in areas such as stroke, PE, cardiology, and oncology. This positions Aidoc not just as a point solution but as an enterprise orchestration layer spanning multiple service lines and modalities, differentiating it from vendors that sell single-indication algorithms.

EXHIBIT 8: Aidoc's aiOS platform provides a unified user interface for accessing results from both Aidoc and third-party algorithms



Source: Aidoc website, Bernstein analysis

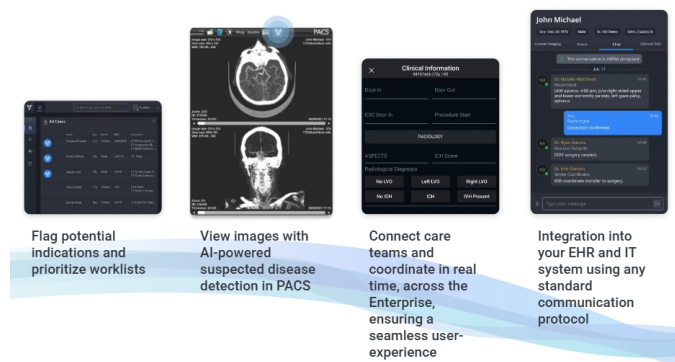
Viz.ai (April 2022 Series D, \$1.2bn valuation)

Viz.ai is a privately held company, headquartered in San Francisco, California. The company's main focus is AI-powered detection and workflow for acute neurovascular and cardiovascular conditions. Viz Radiology is the solution Viz.ai has specifically launched to integrate their software offerings into the radiology workflow. It acts as an enterprise informatics interface and care-coordination infrastructure which integrates with PACS to show AI-flagged cases, reshuffles worklists based on clinical urgency, and provides communication tools that allow radiologists to collaborate with neurology, cardiology, ED, and interventional team (Exhibit 9). This emphasis on speed-to-treatment is especially impactful in time-

sensitive conditions such as stroke, where its algorithms analyze CT images in real time and can significantly reduce the time from diagnosis to interventions.

EXHIBIT 9: Viz.ai radiology solutions

AI-powered care coordination. At the center of clinical decision making.

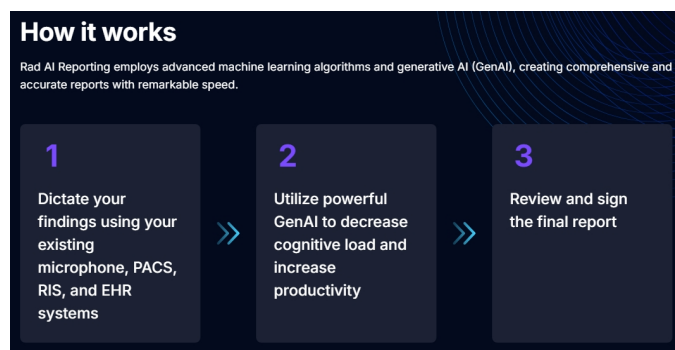


Source: Viz.ai website, Bernstein analysis

Rad AI (May 2025 Series C, \$525m valuation)

Rad AI is a privately held company, headquartered in San Francisco, California. Its core focus is on streamlining radiology reporting. Rad AI Reporting integrates directly with radiologists' existing reporting systems and dictation workflows, using generative AI to auto-draft impressions, carry forward findings, and structure reports while allowing radiologists to dictate or edit in real time (Exhibit 10). The reporting system sits on top of PACS as the primary interface for text generation tied to imaging procedures.

EXHIBIT 10: Rad AI Reporting employs machine learning algorithms and generative AI (GenAI) to assist radiologists to create reports



Source: Rad AI website, Bernstein analysis

Post-processing solutions

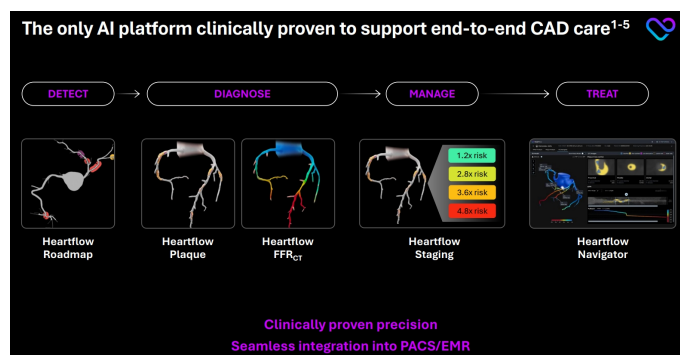
Post-processing solutions represent a critical layer after the acquisition of images. At this stage, raw imaging data is further processed, reconstructed, and analyzed to extract clinically meaningful insights that support radiologists in making diagnostic

decisions. Traditionally, post-processing involved manual adjustments and review, but recent advances in AI have significantly expanded its capabilities. AI-enabled post-processing tools can automatically detect abnormalities, quantify disease burden, prioritize urgent cases, and generate decision support outputs, thereby improving both speed and consistency of interpretation.

HeartFlow (\$2.5bn market cap)

HeartFlow is now a listed company, debuting on the Nasdaq in August, 2025. Its technology focuses on coronary CT angiography: HeartFlow takes CT images acquired in radiology, uploads them to a cloud platform, and applies computational fluid dynamics and AI to generate non-invasive fractional flow reserve (CT-FFR) maps (i.e. using CT and software to estimate how much blood gets past any narrowings in the heart arteries, without having to put a catheter into the heart) that are returned to cardiologists and radiologists as decision-support overlays integrated with existing viewers and reporting systems (Exhibit 11). This means it sits as a post-processing layer hooked into imaging workflow rather than replacing PACS itself, changing the diagnostic pathway for stable coronary disease by reducing the need for invasive angiography.

EXHIBIT 11: HeartFlow is a clinically proven AI platform to support end-to-end CAD care

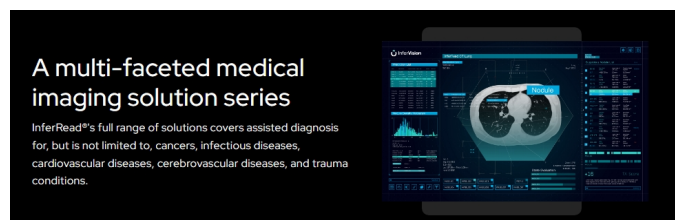


Source: HeartFlow January 2026 investor presentation, Bernstein analysis

InferVision (July 2021 Series D, c.\$700m valuation)

InferVision is a privately held company, headquartered in Philadelphia, US and has a significant presence in Beijing, China, servicing as its global operations center. The company focuses on deep-learning–based detection and quantification of findings on CT and X-ray. InferRead is InferVision's flagship AI-powered medical imaging product suite, designed to support radiologists across multiple body regions, with a particular emphasis on lung CT and chest X-ray interpretation. At its core is InferRead Lung CT.AI, an FDA- and CE-cleared application that automatically performs lung segmentation, detects and labels pulmonary nodules, and now provides quantitative lung density analysis to flag conditions such as emphysema and interstitial lung disease (Exhibit 12).

EXHIBIT 12: InferRead is InferVision's multi-faceted medical imaging solution



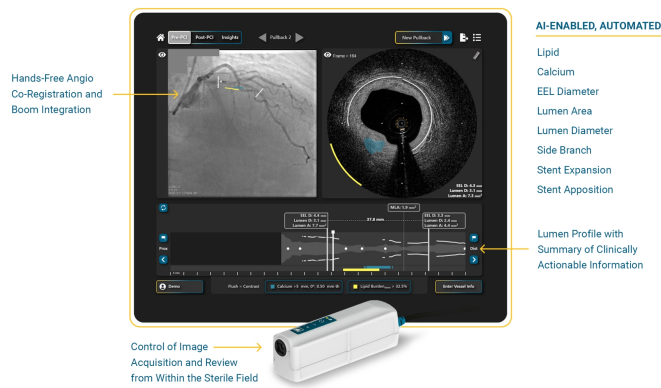
Source: InferRead website, Bernstein analysis

IMPLICATIONS ON THE COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE FOR THE INCUMBENT OEMS

While the new generation of startup companies has emerged to help streamline radiology workstreams and improve throughput, the competitive dynamics of the industry remain heavily influenced by incumbent players. Large imaging companies such as Philips, Siemens Healthineers, and GE Healthcare continue to hold dominant positions due to their installed base, deep integration into clinical environments, and access to large scale patient data, which is only increasing as they grow long-term partnerships with hospitals. These advantages support the development of their own AI capabilities (see [EU Medtech: AI in Medical Imaging & Radiotherapy - Getting Smarter... the Real Opportunities for Artificial Intelligence](#) for further details) but also along with scale enable them to selectively acquire emerging technologies that complement their existing portfolios. Recent examples include Philips' December 2025 acquisition of SpectraWave, a company providing AI-assisted intravascular imaging and physiological assessment solutions (Exhibit 13), as well as GE Healthcare's February 2023 acquisition of Caption Health, integrating AI powered image guidance into its ultrasound portfolio.

Looking ahead, the market is likely to evolve into a hybrid structure in which established players maintain leadership while incorporating best in class innovations from startups either via partnership or in select cases, via acquisition. Meanwhile, the startup ecosystem is expected to remain fragmented, with specialized solutions addressing discrete workflow challenges and focused clinical areas.

EXHIBIT 13: SpectraWave provides AI-enabled, automated Imaging solutions



Source: SpectraWave website, Bernstein analysis

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Ticker	Rating	Cur	10 Jun 2026	Price Target	TTM	Adjusted EPS				Adjusted P/E (x)		
			Closing Price		Rel. Perf.	Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
SN/.LN (Smith & Nephew)	M	GBp	1,160.50	1,170.00	(10.2)%	USD	1.01	1.09	1.22	15.4	14.2	12.8
SNN (Smith & Nephew)	M	USD	30.90	31.85	(20.2)%	USD	2.03	2.19	2.43	15.3	14.1	12.7
PHIA.NA (Philips)	M	EUR	22.46	25.40	(4.5)%	EUR	1.56	1.57	1.74	14.4	14.3	12.9
PHG (Philips ADR)	M	USD	25.67	29.20	(14.1)%	USD	1.76	1.84	2.03	14.6	14.0	12.6
SHL.GR (Healthineers)	O	EUR	34.81	45.70	(38.7)%	EUR	2.38	2.27	2.56	14.6	15.3	13.6
ALC.SW (Alcon)	O	CHF	53.66	73.50	(40.5)%	USD	3.07	3.51	4.22	22.0	19.2	16.0
ALC (Alcon)	O	USD	66.11	93.90	(48.2)%	USD	3.07	3.51	4.22	21.6	18.8	15.7
AFX.GY (Carl Zeiss)	M	EUR	25.70	26.10	(73.4)%	EUR	1.92	1.56	1.79	13.4	16.5	14.4
STMN.SW (Straumann)	O	CHF	94.26	120.00	(28.6)%	CHF	2.99	3.15	3.68	31.5	30.0	25.6
AMP.IM (Amplifon)	M	EUR	10.54	9.85	(63.5)%	EUR	0.71	0.82	0.87	14.7	12.9	12.1
GN.DC (GN Store)	U	DKK	92.52	80.65	(24.2)%	DKK	(1.42)	(0.36)	1.00	(65.2)	(258.4)	92.1
DEMANT.DC (Demant)	O	DKK	253.80	267.00	(25.1)%	DKK	11.66	13.48	15.87	21.8	18.8	16.0
SOON.SW (Sonova)	O	CHF	203.20	248.00	(35.7)%	CHF	9.79	11.12	12.18	20.8	18.3	16.7
EDME			1,541.87									
SPX			7,394.30									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

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